Once it was over, we went for a victory lap and my team-mates decided to carry me around the Wankhede. No one had left the stadium and I waved to the crowd from the shoulders of my team-mates and thanked them for being with me all through my career. I had always hoped that this final lap of honour would be one in victory, because that would mean so much to me as a cricketer. In defeat it would not have had even 10 per cent of the significance it had in victory. We had won the match and the series in style and it meant I had won all of my final matches in all formats of the game.

That was when Virat Kohli reminded me about going out to pay my respect to the pitch and I walked out to the middle by myself. It was a very personal moment and something I had always meant to do at the end of my innings in cricket. I would be no one without the 22-yard strip and it had taken care of me all my life. It was only right to thank the pitch for everything and do *namaskar* (offer my respects).

One final goodbye

As I was sitting by myself back in the dressing room, Virat walked up to me again. I could see tears in his eyes. He held out his hands and said his dad had given him these threads, the kind that Indians wear around their wrists for good luck, and he had always wondered who he would give them to. It had to be someone very special. Then he handed them to me before touching my feet as my younger brother. I was speechless. I held him tight and said, '*Arre tu yeh kya kar raha hain? Tujhe yahan nahi, yahan hona chahiye*.' (What are you doing touching my feet? You should be giving me a hug.) I couldn't say another word because I felt choked with emotion. A lump had formed in my throat and finally I had to ask Virat to leave, knowing I would burst into tears if I tried to say anything else. It was a gesture I can never forget and I wished Virat all the success in his career.

A little later, I called Ajinkya Rahane, my Mumbai team-mate who was our twelfth man in this match, to a room adjoining our dressing room. I had known Rahane for years and had seen how much he loves the game. He had served cricket with complete dedication and commitment over the last few years. I said to him that he might feel hard done by what had happened in his career so far, but he should continue to be the way he is, for I was sure Ajinkya would get another chance. For